

# EV Industry in Uganda — Strategic Research Report

**Date:** June 11, 2026  
**Prepared by:** SyncSphere CEO (with Research agent support)  
**Purpose:** Strategic business planning for SyncSphere's East Africa engagement

## 1. Current State of EVs in Uganda

### Adoption Numbers (2025)

| Segment                        | Count        | Notes                                                               |
|--------------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Electric motorcycles (e-bodas) | ~3,000–3,200 | <1% of Kampala's ~150,000 boda bodas                                |
| Electric buses                 | 24           | Kayoola EVS buses in GKMA                                           |
| Electric cars (4W)             | ~17          | Negligible                                                          |
| Total EVs                      | ~3,000+      | 4th in East Africa (after Ethiopia 115K, Kenya 24.7K, Tanzania 10K) |

### Key Insight

Uganda is an **early-stage market**. EVs are barely penetrated. The dominant segment is electric motorcycles (e-bodas), not cars. This is the "two-wheelers first" pattern seen across East Africa.

## 2. Key Players

### Domestic Manufacturing

- **Kiira Motors Corporation (KMC)** — Uganda's flagship EV company. Producing Kayoola EVS electric buses. Factory in Jinja Industrial Park. Capacity: 2,500 vehicles/year. Target: 500,000/year by 2030. Received UGX 32.5B government funding.
- **GOGO Electric** — E-motorcycle manufacturing + battery swapping. 75% of Li-ion battery value chain. Targeting 150,000 batteries/year by 2026. Received USD 3M from Uganda Development Bank.
- **Soleil Power** — First dedicated Li-ion pack assembly plant in East Africa. 14,000–20,000 batteries/year capacity.

### Ride-Hailing & Fleet

- **SafeBoda** — Uganda's largest ride-hailing platform. Launched "Electric Boda" EV tier. Exited Nigeria to focus on Uganda profitability.
- **Zembo** — Electric boda-boda pioneer. Battery swapping at scale. Cross-border rides from Busia.
- **Spiro Uganda** — Reports growth from <1,000 to 4,000+ EV bodas in one year. Secured \$50M Afreximbank loan.
- **Bodawerk** — Local EV motorcycle company.

## Charging Infrastructure

- **5 commercial charging stations** under development (as of 2024)
- **100+ battery swapping stations** operational (e-motorcycle focused)
- First public EV charging station launched April 2025 at Amber House, Kampala
- **Total** (French major) set up 13 EV charging stations

## Financing

- **MOGO Uganda** — Leading EV financier. Financed 1,500+ electric motorcycles as of May 2025.
  - **Uganda Development Bank (UDB)** — Climate finance lines for e-mobility.
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## 3. Government Policy

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### National E-Mobility Strategy (2023)

- **Vision:** Full public transport & motorcycle electrification by 2030, passenger vehicle sales by 2040
- **7 strategic objectives:** Local manufacturing, battery production, public transport electrification, charging network, EV uptake, standards development, human capital
- **20-year roadmap** — positions Uganda as a net exporter of e-mobility solutions to Africa

### Tax & Fiscal Incentives

- **Import duty:** 25% (reversed from zero-rated in mid-2024 — a setback)
- **VAT exemptions** on EVs and components
- **Stamp duty exemptions** for local manufacturers
- **Tax incentives** on charging and battery swapping services
- **Government fleet electrification** commitments

### Regulatory

- Imported EVs must be ≤15 years old
- Euro 4 environmental standards
- 80% Ugandan employment & raw material sourcing target
- EAC standards harmonization

### Key Concern

The reversal from zero-rated to 25% import duty in mid-2024 is a **significant policy setback** that increases EV costs. Stakeholders are pushing for restoration of incentives.

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## 4. Charging Infrastructure

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### Current State

- **Grid:** 96% hydroelectric — one of the cleanest grids in Africa. This is Uganda's biggest competitive advantage for EVs.

- **Electricity access:** 57% national coverage (expanding)
- **Karuma Power Plant:** Commissioned 2024 — additional generation capacity
- **5 commercial charging stations** operational or under development
- **100+ battery swapping stations** (motorcycle-focused)
- **Solar-powered charging** along Kampala–Masaka corridor

## Plans

- 2,000 mini-grids by 2030 (National Electrification Strategy)
- Urban + highway charging network
- Jinja Industrial Park as EV production hub

## Bottleneck

Charging infrastructure is the **#1 barrier** to EV adoption. Outside Kampala and major corridors, coverage is minimal.

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## 5. Market Opportunities

### High-Potential Segments

1. **E-boda financing** — MOGO has proven the model. 1,500+ financed. Huge unmet demand (150,000+ petrol bodas in Kampala alone).
2. **Battery swapping infrastructure** — 100+ stations exist but need massive scaling. Pay-as-you-go model works.
3. **Electric bus assembly/manufacturing** — Kiira Motors is scaling. Government committed to public transport electrification by 2030.
4. **Local battery manufacturing** — GOGO and Soleil Power are early movers. Import substitution opportunity.
5. **Solar charging stations** — Uganda's hydro grid + solar = truly green charging. Exportable model.
6. **EV ride-hailing** — SafeBoda's EV tier is early but growing. Fleet electrification partnerships.
7. **Used EV imports** — Japan/Europe used EVs at 15-year age limit. Cost-effective entry point.

### Investment Landscape

- **USD 100M+ invested** in Uganda e-mobility (2018–2024)
  - **70% government-funded** historically
  - **USD 800M private pipeline** projected
  - **Africa E-Mobility Report 2025:** 208 active companies across Africa, 98 in East Africa
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## 6. Barriers

| Barrier                         | Severity | Detail                                               |
|---------------------------------|----------|------------------------------------------------------|
| High upfront costs              | Critical | EVs cost 2-3x more than petrol equivalents           |
| Limited charging infrastructure | Critical | Outside Kampala, almost no coverage                  |
| Policy inconsistency            | High     | Import duty reversal in 2024 hurt confidence         |
| Grid capacity outside cities    | Medium   | 57% national electricity access                      |
| Limited financing options       | Medium   | MOGO is growing but undercapitalized                 |
| Skills gap                      | Medium   | Need trained technicians for maintenance             |
| Consumer awareness              | Medium   | Most Ugandans don't know EVs exist                   |
| Import dependency               | High     | Almost all EVs imported; local manufacturing nascent |

## 7. Comparable Markets — East Africa Comparison

| Country  | Total EVs      | % of Fleet | Policy Strength | Key Strength                                        |
|----------|----------------|------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Ethiopia | ~115,000       | ~8%        | ★★★★★           | Banned ICE imports; state-led                       |
| Rwanda   | ~5,500         | ~1.4%      | ★★★★★           | Tax exemptions; restricted petrol boda registration |
| Kenya    | ~24,754        | ~0.5%      | ★★★☆☆           | Market-driven; draft policy pending                 |
| Tanzania | ~10,000 (2/3W) | Low        | ★★★☆☆           | Highest 2/3W deployment                             |
| Uganda   | ~3,000         | <0.1%      | ★★★☆☆           | Clean grid; manufacturing base                      |

### Key Lessons

- **Ethiopia proves** state mandates work (banned ICE → 115K EVs)
- **Rwanda proves** targeted incentives work (restricted petrol bodas → rapid EV adoption)
- **Kenya shows** what happens without policy (innovation exists but scaling stalls)
- **Uganda's advantage:** 96% hydro grid + Kiira Motors manufacturing base + government commitment
- **Uganda's disadvantage:** Policy inconsistency (duty reversal), low electricity access outside cities

## 8. SyncSphere Relevance

### Strategic Fit

Given SyncSphere's existing relationship with **Swangz Avenue Ltd** (Ugandan music label) and East Africa focus:

1. **Digital infrastructure for EV ecosystem** — SyncSphere deploys OSS tools (n8n, Listmonk, Plausible). These are directly applicable to:
  - EV fleet management platforms
  - Battery swapping payment/CRM systems

- Charging station monitoring dashboards
  - EV ride-hailing backend services
2. **Website & digital presence** — Every Ugandan EV company (Kiira Motors, GOGO, Spiro, Zembo, SafeBoda) needs professional web presence. SyncSphere's web dev capability is immediately relevant.
  3. **Social media management** — EV companies need brand building. SyncSphere's Marketing agent can serve this need.
  4. **Regional play** — Uganda is the gateway to landlocked neighbors (South Sudan, DRC, Rwanda, Burundi). A successful Uganda engagement creates a beachhead.

## Recommended Approach

- **Phase 1:** Offer digital services (web, social, automation) to existing Ugandan EV companies
- **Phase 2:** Build EV-specific SaaS tools (fleet management, charging station monitoring)
- **Phase 3:** Expand regionally using Uganda as the base

## Caveat

This is a **long-term play**. Uganda's EV market is tiny today (<0.1% penetration). But the trajectory is clear: government commitment + clean grid + growing investment = significant opportunity in 3-5 years. Early positioning matters.

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## Sources

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